Jabber

By Marcus Youssef

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: Actor – Actor 1; Actor 1/3; Melissa's Friend; Father, and Jorah
Actress -- Actor 2; Actor 2/3; History Teacher; and Fatima

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 3-5)** Hey. I'm *(actor name)*

ACTOR 2: Hey. I'm *(actor name)* . . . . Let's say we're in a high school.

ACTOR 1: Oh look, we are. Let's say her name is Fatima.

ACTOR 2: Let's say Fatima's only been in _____ *(insert location. Original script designates Canada)* for a couple of years.

ACTOR 1: Let's say the country she's from is, like nine thousand kilometers away.

ACTOR 2: And there was some kind of war –

ACTOR 1/3: Let's say her parents just forced her to switch schools and come to this one because of something that happened at her old school . . . . Something bad.

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *Jabber by Marcus Youssef.*

FATIMA: Not bad, just stupid. I was with my friends, Seema and Hama and Lindsay. Lindsay's a white girl, but she hangs out with us. We call ourselves the jabbers. Cuz of the hijab. Ha ha. When we get to school, there's like four police cars and a pile of cops. Standing around the wall outside the gym. Staring and pointing and talking into their walkie-talkies. It was just some graffiti.

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MELISSA'S FRIEND: **(Pg 32)** What did the graffiti say?

FATIMA: "All Muslims must die."

MELISSA'S FRIEND: Eww. That's so racist.

FATIMA: Yeah. Anyway . . . **(Pg 5-7)** My parents totally freaked out. They were, like,

FATHER: "You are not safe, you must change schools. It was a threat, Fatima. You must remember: These people are full of hate. I will do whatever necessary to protect you from these animals."

FATIMA: By forcing me to come here, a subway and two buses from where we live. St. Mary's. There's no Seema, or Hama. No jabbers at all. Let's say today is my first day.

ACTOR 1: Let's say my name is Jorah

ACTOR 2/3: Let's say he's that guy that people are a little afraid of –

ACTOR 1: He did something

ACTOR 2/3: Something bad -- Rumors – Let's say maybe none of those rumors are true – Or maybe they are.

ACTOR 1: Today he got in trouble.

ACTOR 2: He was in history class – and the teacher was telling them about what happened to Jewish people in World War Two, how the German army put them in gas ovens . . . and the teacher noticed Jorah not listening, so he called him out, in front of everyone.

HISTORY TEACHER: What do you think of that Jorah . . . The Nazis taking people – real, living human beings – and baking them alive in ovens.

JORAH: You mean, like pizza? Little mini dudes, all covered in cheese.

HISTORY TEACHER: Do you even know what you're saying?

ACTOR 1/3: Let's say Fatima was in the class and on their way out

ACTOR 2: He stared at her, for a while

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ACTOR 1: Because of her scarf.

FATIMA: I know what they're thinking. Whoa. What's with the scarf? I bet she has to wear it. I wonder if she's a terrorist. I bet she's really, like, timid . . . . any of those things. *(to Jorah, challenging)* Hi. *(to audience)* I'm not shy. But it's also, hijab, it's part of who I am.

JORAH: **(Pg 13-17)** You're new. If you're planning on blowing up the school, I'm in.

FATIMA: Excuse me?

JORAH: A lot of kids would thank you. You'd be a hero. You know what? I'll help. I'm ready. Just give me the signal. Nobody'll suspect me cuz I don't look like a terrorist.

FATIMA: Like me. *(Beat)*

JORAH: What's your name? *(Fatima ignores him)* Oh, I get it. You don't want to blow your cover. You'd be a crap terrorist if you told people your real name.

FATIMA: Ha ha. Fatima.

JORAH: Fatima . . Mind if I call you Fat?

FATIMA: No. Mind if I call you a-hole? *(Jorah reacts to her use of profanity)* You think because I'm Muslim, I can't swear?

JORAH: A-hole's not exactly a swear. You got, like some wicked forehead zits? Covering up some major pus bombs? That why you got the head thing?

FATIMA: My scarf? It's part of my religion.

JORAH: It's called a Taliban, right?

FATIMA: Taliban? Oh, my God. Now that's funny. Taliban are the guys who are fighting in Afghanistan. It's called a hijab.

JORAH: Oh. Do you wear it all the time? . . . In the shower? In bed?

FATIMA: I only have to wear it in public. I don't wear it at home.

JORAH: Is it to stop you from turning guys on?

FATIMA: Oh, my God. It's to show humility. Before God.

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JORAH: Is it, like, those Taliban guys might think you're so hot, they'd see your hair and just, like, lose control? I saw this old Chuck Norris movie where they catch a bad, like, Muslim Taliban dude and tie him up and force bacon down his throat. It was pretty funny.

FATIMA: **(Pg 18)** Huh. I saw this movie once about this dumb white boy who talked about a lot of crap he wasn't smart enough to understand. Oh hang on, that wasn't a move. That's what's happening right now. . . *(Fatima starts to leave)* By the way, if you say any more weird, racist, or insulting things to me, I will use my terrorist skills to kick you in the crotch so hard you'll be down on your knees begging for your life. Just sayin' *(Exiting)* See ya.

****** (Scene change) – Fatima arrives home*******

FATIMA: **(Pg 22-23)** *(Speaking to her parents on her way to her room)* It was fine, thank you. I'm going to my room. Homework. *(to audience)* We moved three years ago. I was thirteen. You climb on a plane, fly for two days, and you land in the middle of winter. I'd never seen snow in my life. I spent a lot of time on my computer. Convinced them I needed it in my room – for homework. I sped a lot of time on TeenChat. I don't talk. I just watch. Teenagers. They're all white. That's how I learned to speak English. I watch them. Girls, talking to guys. Flirt and smile and make faces. It's shocking what these girls do. "Oh, my God, what? No! I love you. You can't tell them." Is that normal? Not for jabbers . . .

****** (Scene change) – Jorah and Fatima video chat*******

FATIMA: **(Pg 49-51)** Hi

JORAH: Smile. . . . just do it. Please? *(She smiles)* You look awesome. **(Pg 43)** I googled how to talk to Muslim girls. It said to tell you I saw your hair, so that means you have to marry me.

FATIMA: **(Pg 39)** If my parents knew I was even talking to you, they'd kill me. And

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they'd kill you too. They'd track you down.

JORAH: Seriously?

FATIMA: Oh yeah. They'd go all ISIS on you.

JORAH: Ha ha. You could stand up to them. Tell them it's different here. You have a right to do what you want. **(Pg 41)** The whole Muslim thing? It's kind of super-hot!

FATIMA: **(Pg 49-51)** I've never done this before. Back home I wouldn't have even thought of it. There would have been no way. But here . . . it's like everyone can do whatever they want . . . so the weirdest thing happened today? I overheard . . . somebody was talking about your dad.

JORAH: What did they say? Who? *(Beat)* **(Pg 53-55)** People think they know. They think they know about him, and me. But they don't That don't know anything. *(Beat)*

FATIMA: You can trust me. *(Beat)* I've never – what we're doing – this? If my parents found out, I'd be dead. For me to do – even this – with a boy, it's the most shameful thing they could imagine. And I know you don't understand, but if I'm going to do that, I need to know who I'm doing it with.

JORAH: You're not like your parents, right? Me too. I'm different that my dad too.

FATIMA: Tell me. *(A long beat)*

JORAH: I was in my room, and they were fighting in the kitchen. I looked down the hall. Mom was holding her face, and there was broken stuff on the floor, and he was pacing back and forth. He was crying, and throwing s***, and yelling he was sorry all at the same time. After, people looked at me different. Like I was dangerous. Like they had a reason to be scared. It was all over the news. If you google our name, it's what comes up. He got three years, with no parole, because they said it wasn't the first time. That

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thee was a "pattern of abuse." Which I guess is true. But, honestly, until I heard the ambulance that day, I hadn't ever really noticed.

FATIMA: Oh, Jorah. I'm so sorry. Did he ever . . . hurt you?

JORAH: No. I mean, I don't know. Not really.

FATIMA: **(Pg 56-57)** Jorah . . I won't tell anyone . . . trust me. *(blows a kiss)* I know what it's like to have people think you're a freak. To want to be like everybody else. *(She starts to remove her hijab, showing more of her hair – This is a very big deal in her culture)* . . . I trust you. *(blows a kiss)*

****** (Scene change) – The next day at school *******

JORAH: **(Pg 60-63)** Hey. I've been trying to find you. (Fatima is embarrassed and feeling very guilty – she doesn't respond or even look at Jorah) I brought you something . . . a surprise . . . You have really pretty hair. Here (handing her a print of a photograph) It's [a] screenshot.

FATIMA: *(panicked)* You can't show this to anybody. I could get in so much trouble.

JORAH: You trust me, remember?

FATIMA: You don't understand. I shouldn't have taken off my scarf.

JORAH: Why not? You wanted to. What's the big deal?

FATIMA: My whole life, that's what. . . And my family . . . and my religion. What I did is a sin – a sin against God.

JORAH: Showing me your hair?

FATIMA: You don't understand. We're too different *(Beat)*

JORAH: *(Angry – taking back the photograph)* "The most beautiful girl in the world." That's what I wrote on it *(ripping it up)* There. Now you're safe. *(He stalks off)*

****** (Scene change)******

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 72-75)** Let's say that night Fatima got a text

ACTOR 2: Check Facebook. Now!!!! . . . . it was a new page.

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ACTOR 1: "My Muslim ex-girlfriend takes off her hijab"

ACTOR 2/3: Let's say Jorah had recorded their chats because sometimes he hates how girls treat him – like he's already done something wrong.

FATIMA: I showed my parents. It was the hardest thing I've ever done. I said, "All I did was blow kisses and show him some hair." I was crying, but I was, like "What's the big deal? Is that really so bad? Do you know what girls do online?"

ACTOR 2: Sometimes people do things that they regret.

ACTOR 1/3: Let's say Fatima's parents freaked out. . .

ACTOR 2: [There was] a Muslim family in another part of the country who murdered their two daughters because they thought they had dishonored their family. . .

ACTOR 1/3: Fatima's parents surprised her . . .

FATIMA: [The] next day they told me my punishment . . . . No more computer in my room.

ACTOR 1/3: [They] let her go back to her old school and reunite with Seema, Hama and Lindsay.

ACTOR 2: **(Forward)** Both Fatima and Jorah live under a cloud

ACTOR 1: Because of her religion

ACTOR 2: Because of his past.

ACTOR 1: Both are smothered by assumptions and preconceptions.

ACTOR 2: The tension comes from [the] expectation of irrational violence – and that is exactly [the author's] point. We've been conditioned to expect the worst.

ACTOR 1: **(PG 75)** There's almost two billion Muslim people in the world.

ACTOR 2/3: They're not all the same.

ACTOR 1: [And not every child will follow in the violent footsteps of his father.]

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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